PROJECT DECISIONS

“Looks Good” Is How the Wrong Fixture Gets Ordered

Make it clear what a client approved and what the team can do next.



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The client texts “looks good” under a photo of a brass pendant. The designer marks lighting approved. Purchasing sees the item in the schedule and releases it. When the electrician opens the submittal, he finds that the approved image is a finish sample and the order is for a fixture with a different canopy and driver. The client recognizes the brass. The ceiling detail is still unresolved.

A company can have an approval, an order, and a client who meant something narrower than either record suggests. It has to decide what the word “approved” allows the next person to do.

A useful approval records the exact item and version, who authorized it, what they agreed to, and what action follows. Keep aesthetic selection, technical review, price and schedule changes, and release to order distinct where they have different decision makers or consequences.

What does a client approval actually authorize?

It authorizes the decision the approver was asked to make within their authority. Ask explicitly whether the person is choosing a finish, approving a substitution, accepting a commercial change, or releasing something to order. Attach the evidence the next person will rely on.

AIA’s construction documents distinguish an agreed change order from a construction change directive used when work is directed before agreement on the contract price or time adjustment. The forms apply in particular contractual settings. The operational lesson for a design team is useful at a smaller scale. A decision to proceed and an agreement about price or schedule can be two different events. Record the difference. AIA G701 change order · AIA G714 construction change directive

For a pendant, “finish selected” can let the designer update the schedule. “Technical fit confirmed” can let the electrician coordinate with the ceiling detail. “Price and lead time accepted” can be a condition for an authorized person to release the order. If all three are needed, the person who orders should be able to see all three in the same place.

How should teams handle a substitution after approval?

Treat the substitute as a new item and compare it against the decisions already made. Keep the original approval visible. Reopen the decisions the change affects and carry forward only those that still apply.

If an item is out of stock on Costco Same-Day, the customer can set a replacement preference, ask for a refund if the item is unavailable, or respond to a replacement the shopper suggests. The choice is attached to the item. Agreeing to a replacement for one product says nothing about another item in the cart. In a studio, make that boundary equally visible. A client who approved the brass finish has made one decision. The electrician still needs to check the new model's fit, and someone still needs to accept its price. Costco Same-Day help, replacement preferences

What changed on the pendant	What still holds	What to confirm before release
Supplier offers the same fixture in the selected finish, with a longer lead time.	Selected finish and confirmed technical details, if the model is identical.	Delivery date and schedule consequence.
Similar pendant in the same finish, with a different canopy.	The direction the client chose.	Fit with the ceiling and the client's acceptance of any visible difference.
Alternate driver requires different controls and costs more.	Any design decisions unaffected by the driver change.	Compatibility, added cost, and the approval required by the project.

The team can send a focused question. "The brass finish stays the same. This model has a wider canopy and would arrive two weeks earlier. Here's the ceiling detail. Are you approving the visible change? We'll confirm controls and price before ordering." One message can clarify what the client owns and show what the team still has to do.

What happens if the customer wants to proceed before the price is settled?

Separate work that can continue from the part that creates a commitment. A designer may be able to reserve a product without cost while pricing is confirmed. A noncancelable purchase or a change to the ceiling has a different consequence. Check who can authorize the action under the project's agreement and record what the company has permission to do now.

An illustrative record could say "Owner selected the wider canopy. Supplier agreed to hold stock until Tuesday. Electrical review and acceptance of the added cost are pending. Purchasing can reserve stock and will wait for release before placing the order." If reserving stock itself requires a deposit, that fact changes the record and the approval you need. The action is small enough to state and specific enough for the next employee to follow.

What belongs in an approval record people will actually use?

Keep the requested decision, the item and revision, the person with authority, the response and date, and the next action together. If the decision is conditional, show the condition in the place people check before acting. Link an older approval to the one that superseded it.

In the **Approval Record** for the pendant, record "finish only, champagne brass sample, approved by owner on 14 November." Add the exact proposed model and its technical review status. Show the order as pending under the purchasing lead, with a link to price and delivery confirmation. The original text belongs in the record as evidence. The status belongs where the next person works.

Review five recent orders and ask someone from purchasing to identify what each order was released against. Check the approved versions and any later substitutes. If decisions take a week to locate, measure the time lost. If orders can be released with only a finish selected, the issue is what the workflow permits. Test a change on one kind of selection and check whether routine approvals still move.

Three checks before ordering a selected item.

- Show exactly which object and revision the client saw.
- Give each decision a clear scope and an authorized person.
- Put an explicit release decision in front of the person who commits the money.

When the client says “looks good” to the next brass sample, the designer can record the choice as made. Purchasing can see what is still open before a fixture leaves the warehouse.

Frequently asked questions

Can a text message count as an approval?

It can record the response. Capture the question it answered, the item or revision, who sent it, and the action authorized under the project’s agreed procedure.

Does changing a selection require every approval to be repeated?

Review which earlier decisions still apply. Reopen the ones affected by the change and show the remaining conditions to the person who will order or install it.

Do you need new software to fix approvals?

Start by making the decision and next action visible in the tools the team already checks. Consider a new tool if the process works in a small test and the existing tools cannot reliably preserve versions, ownership or release status.

The pendant is illustrative. AIA and Costco are public references for distinguishing decisions and their scope.